to be fine-grained enough to use the nontransactional behavior for only a single spec. Again, if you need to test transactional behavior, fixtures may not be your best bet.

Why Fixtures Are Great

Fixtures have a bad reputation in some circles, but they do have their good points. Used judiciously, fixtures are a fast way to create background static data.

Fixtures Are Fast

One reason to use fixtures in a modern Rails application is how fast they are. They add overhead only when the Rails framework is loaded; there's no real cost to having fixtures persist between tests, so there's no particular downside to having a lot of objects defined in fixture files.

Well, there's *one* downside: sometimes you might write a test that assumes the database table is blank, so you'd test something that's supposed to create an object and then test that there's exactly one object in the database. The existence of fixture data will break that test because you'll start with objects in the database. One workaround is to explicitly test the change between the initial state and the ending state rather than assuming the start state is an empty table.

Fixture speed makes fixtures ideal for setting up reasonably complicated object-relationship trees that you might use in your tests. That said, if you're truly unit-testing, you likely don't need complicated object-relationship trees. (If you're acceptance-testing, on the other hand … hold that thought.)

Fixtures Are Always There

You can count on fixtures always being available anywhere in your test suite. In many unit-testing situations that's not a big deal because you don't create a lot of data for each test.

However, some applications rely on the existence of some kind of mostly static data that's stored in the database. Often this is metadata, product types, user types, or categories of some kind. It's stored in the database to make it easy to modify, but most of the time it's static data. If your application assumes that kind of data will always be there, setting that data up via fixtures will be faster and easier than re-creating the data for each test.

Prescription 16	Fixtures are particularly useful for global semistatic data stored in the database.